

THE TRIGGER
Jobless youths protesting in Dehradun on Feb. 9, (inset) Uttarakhand CM Pushkar Singh Dhami

ARUN PARDESHI

UTTARAKHAND/ ANTI-COPYING LAW

COPY, AND BE JAILED

By Anilesh S. Mahajan

Local news channels were still discussing the alleged police high-handedness in dealing with violence that had erupted during the student protests against recruitment scams and paper leaks in Uttarakhand when something else came along: an ordinance from Chief Minister Pushkar Singh Dhami with extraordinarily stringent measures to curb cheating during exams. Called the Uttarakhand Competitive Examination (Measures for Prevention and Redressal of Unfair Means in Recruitment) Ordinance, it provides for 10-year jail to those found guilty of copying, and life imprisonment to those facilitating them—a reminder of a similar anti-copying law passed in unified Uttar Pradesh in 1992.

That law had snowballed into a major political issue after then UP CM Kalyan Singh's regime allowed cops to enter exam halls and arrest students caught cheating. As photos of handcuffed students were flashed in newspapers, the negative public sentiment was exploited by Singh's rival Mulayam Singh Yadav, who scrapped the law after returning to power in 1993.

BACKED BY A STRINGENT LAW, THE DHAMI GOVERNMENT IS READY TO CRACK THE WHIP ON THE STATE'S 'CHEATING MAFIA'

The new law, which got the approval of Uttarakhand Governor Lt Gen. Gurmit Singh (retd) on February 10, is perceived to be Dhami's brainchild and was in the works for almost a year. The idea is born of noble intent: to curb the state's "cheating mafia", which has had quite a stranglehold on the state's exam ecosystem of late. In the past decade, Uttarakhand has seen a series of paper leaks. Most recently, the exam for recruitment of patwaris and accountants held in January had to be cancelled and re-conducted in mid-February. This, even as the Dhami-led Bharatiya Janata Party